CYBER AWARENESS HANDBOOK

Spot scams. Protect your data. Stay safe online.



Follow **Harman, Daman, Raman, Jassi** and their AI cyber-cat **Byte** through 10 real-life online situations, and learn exactly what to look for and what to do.

Phishing | Passwords | Privacy | Fake Shops | QR Codes | Wi-Fi

CHOOSE YOUR MISSION

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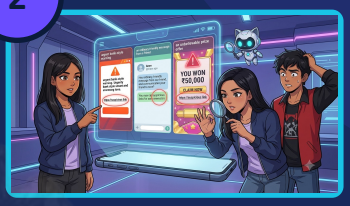
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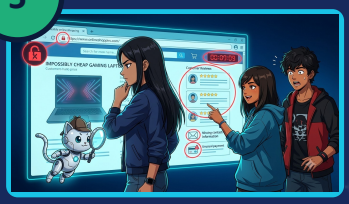
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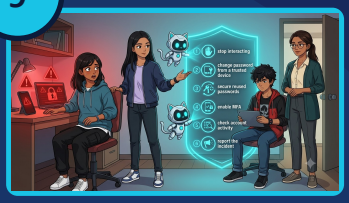
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Welcome

Online scams can target **anyone**: students, parents, shopkeepers, grandparents. Scammers do not need to be clever hackers. They only need you to **click, share or pay in a hurry**

The good news: a few simple habits stop most of them.

This handbook teaches those habits through 10 short stories. Every page uses the same layout, so you can find what you need quickly.

HOW EACH PAGE WORKS

1 The Story

What happens in the poster and why it matters.

2 Red flags

The warning signs you can spot in seconds.

3 Do and Don't

Simple actions that keep you protected.

4 If it already happened

What to do next if you were caught out.

10 real-life stories **5** quick checks **1** safer you

Meet the Team

MEET THE TEAM

A

Harman

Curious and energetic. Asks the questions we are all thinking.

M

Daman

Calm and analytical. Checks the facts before acting.

R

Raman

Funny and impulsive. Learns the hard way so you do not have to.

S

Jassi

Calm mentor. Guides the team when things go wrong.

B

Byte

AI cyber-cat mascot. Pops up with warnings and quick tips.

Together they turn every scam into a lesson. You will meet them again on every page.

1 The Mysterious Message

UNEXPECTED PRIZE SCAMS



THE STORY

Harman gets a message saying she has **won ₹50,000**. Before she taps the link, Daman, Raman and Byte spot the danger. Scammers use exciting offers to make you click fast and hand over personal or bank details.

Red flags

- You never entered any contest or lottery
- The message says “claim now”
- The link looks odd and matches no real company
- It comes from an unknown number or email

Do

- Stop. Do not tap the link
- Screenshot it if you plan to report it
- Block the sender and delete the message
- Warn family and friends

Don't

- Do not reply to unknown senders
- Never share OTP, PIN, card or Aadhaar details
- Do not pay a “fee” or “tax” to get a prize
- Do not forward the message

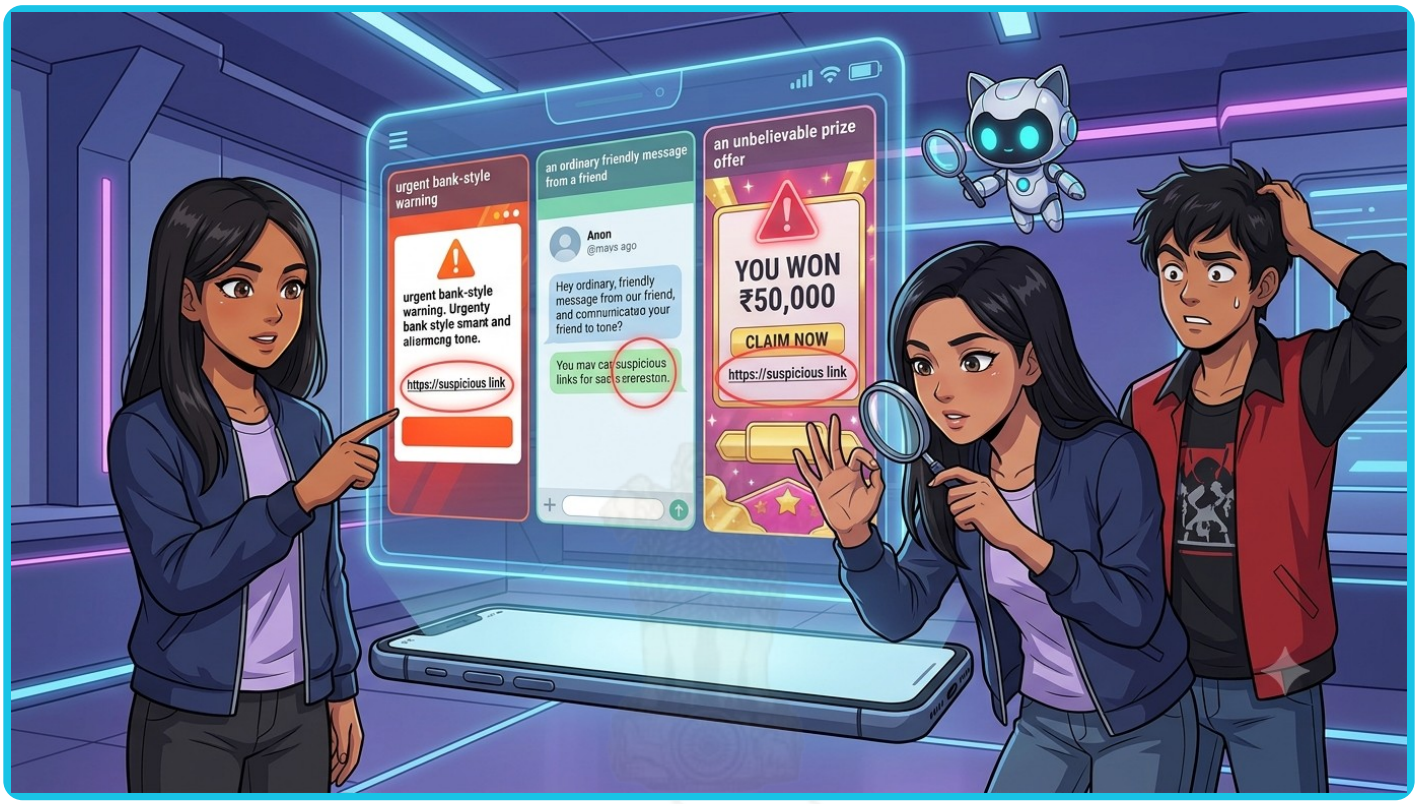
IF IT ALREADY HAPPENED

Clicked but entered nothing? Close the page and run a security scan. Shared details or paid money? Jump to **Scene 9** and call **1930** (National Cyber Crime Helpline) straight away.

BYTE'S GOLDEN RULE **Real prizes never ask you to pay or click first. If it sounds too good to be true, it is.**

2 Spot the Phish

PHISHING MESSAGES



THE STORY

Phishing is a fake message that pretends to be your bank, a company or a friend to steal your information. Daman compares three messages: a bank-style alarm, a friendly chat and a too-good-to-be-true prize. Only one is normal.

The 4 warning signs

- **Urgency:** "Act in 1 hour or lose access"
- **Unknown sender:** number or email you do not recognise
- **Suspicious link:** odd spelling or unfamiliar website
- **Unexpected prize** or request for money

Do

- Pause for 10 seconds before acting
- Open your bank's official app or type the website yourself
- Call the number on your card or official site
- Press and hold a link to preview it (do not tap)

Don't

- Do not trust a message just because it looks official
- Banks never ask for OTP, PIN, CVV or passwords
- Do not open attachments you did not expect
- Do not call numbers given inside the message

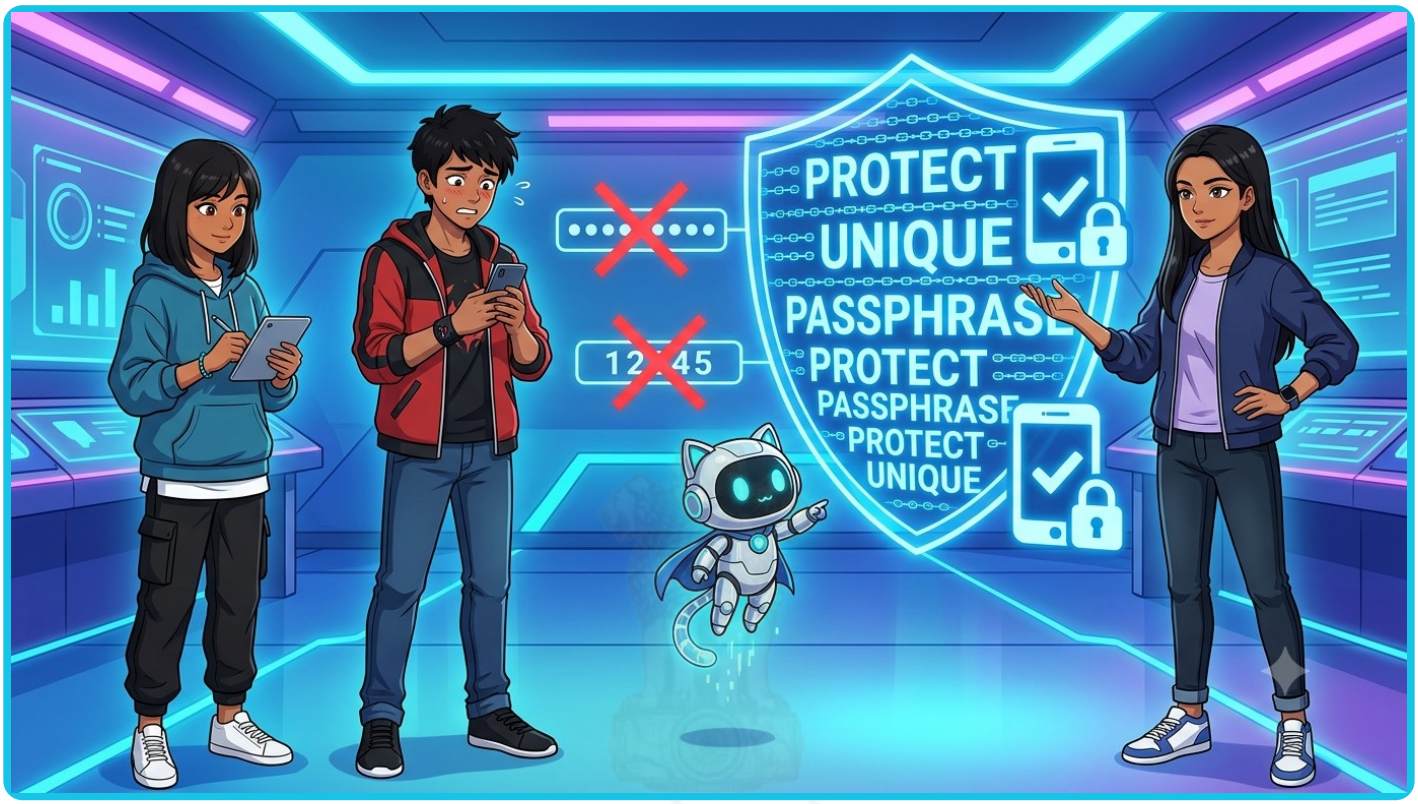
CAREFUL WITH FRIENDS TOO

A message from a friend can be fake if their account was hacked. If it feels unusual, such as an odd link or a request for money, call them to check.

BYTE'S GOLDEN RULE **Urgency + unknown sender + link + prize = phish. Spot any one and stop.**

3 Password Power-Up

PASSWORDS AND MFA



THE STORY

Raman is embarrassed to learn his password is weak. Daman shows the fix: a **long, unique passphrase** acts like a shield, and **MFA** (multi-factor authentication) adds a second lock.

Weak passwords	Do	Don't
• 123456, password, qwerty • Your name, phone number or birth year • One password reused on many accounts • Short passwords with only letters	• Use a passphrase of 4 or more random words (12+ characters) • Use a different password for each important account • Save them in a trusted password manager • Turn on MFA for email, banking and social media	• Never share passwords or OTPs • Do not keep passwords on sticky notes • Do not approve a login prompt you did not start • Do not use your pet or family name

BUILD YOUR OWN PASSPHRASE

Pick 4 random words, add a number and a symbol. **Example style:** Purple-Mango-Train-Rides-42! (make your own, never use this exact one). MFA means a second proof, such as a code from an authenticator app, in addition to your password.

BYTE'S GOLDEN RULE **Long + unique + MFA = a shield that is very hard to break.**

4 The Social Media Trap

OVERSHARING AND PRIVACY



THE STORY

Harman is about to post that she is off on holiday and the house will be empty. Daman stops her just in time. Posts that reveal your **location, dates and home** can tell thieves and strangers exactly when nobody is around.

What not to reveal

- Live location or check-ins
- Travel dates and “house empty” hints
- Photos of tickets, boarding passes or your house number
- Phone number, school, workplace, birthday

Do

- Post holiday photos after you are back
- Set your account to private and review followers
- Turn off location tagging on photos
- Use a “close friends” list for personal updates

Don't

- Do not post tickets, boarding passes or QR codes
- Do not accept requests from strangers
- Do not share your address or daily routine
- Do not tag your location in real time

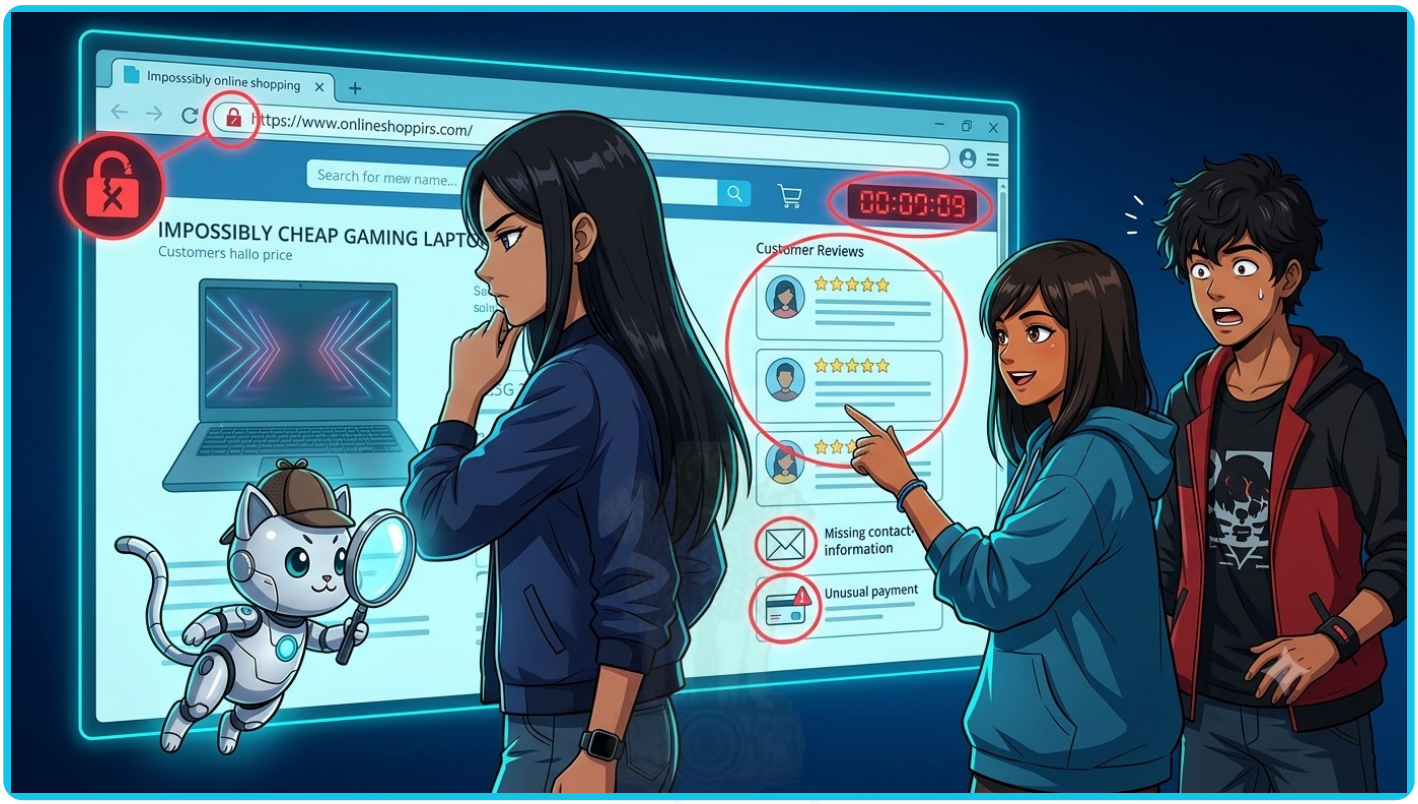
IF IT ALREADY HAPPENED

Delete or hide the post, remove location tags, and ask a trusted neighbour or relative to keep an eye on the house. Check who can see your old posts.

BYTE'S GOLDEN RULE **Post after you are back. Once it is online, you cannot control who saves it.**

5 Scam Detective

FAKE SHOPPING WEBSITES



THE STORY

The team investigates a gaming laptop at an impossible price. Daman checks the web address, Harman spots copy-paste reviews and Raman notices a pressure timer. Together they find the signs of a **fake shop**.

Red flags

- Strange web address (spelling tricks, odd endings)
- Fake urgency: countdown timers, “only 2 left”
- Identical or too-perfect reviews
- No contact details, address or return policy
- Payment only to a personal UPI ID or bank account

Do

- Compare the price with trusted stores
- Search the shop name + “reviews” or “scam”
- Check contact details and return policy
- Prefer Cash on Delivery or well-known platforms

Don't

- Do not pay by direct transfer to a person
- Do not save card details on unknown sites
- Do not trust ads or social pages alone
- Do not let a timer rush you

IF IT ALREADY HAPPENED

Contact your bank at once, keep screenshots, receipts and transaction IDs, and report at **cybercrime.gov.in** or call **1930**. Remember: a padlock icon only means the connection is encrypted, not that the shop is honest.

BYTE'S GOLDEN RULE **If the price is impossible and the clock is ticking, walk away.**

6 The QR Code Mystery

QR CODE SCAMS



THE STORY

A poster offers free concert tickets through a big QR code. Harman is about to scan it when Daman raises her hand. A QR code is just a shortcut to a **link**, and scammers can hide a dangerous website or payment request behind it.

Red flags

- QR codes from unknown posters, stickers or flyers
- A sticker placed over an original QR code
- Offers that are free, urgent or too good
- Asks for a UPI PIN or card details after scanning

Do

- Check who put the poster up and whether it looks tampered
- Preview the link your scanner shows before opening
- Read the website name carefully
- Use the official website or app to buy tickets

Don't

- **You never need a PIN to receive money.** Do not enter it
- Do not install apps from a QR code
- Do not scan codes sent by strangers
- Do not log in on pages opened by a QR code

IF IT ALREADY HAPPENED

If you entered details or paid, call your bank immediately, change affected passwords and report at **1930**. Keep the screenshot of the poster and transaction.

BYTE'S GOLDEN RULE **Scanning is like clicking a link. Check the source and the destination first.**

7 Cyberbullying: Choose Your Move

ONLINE BULLYING



THE STORY

Raman sees hurtful comments online, and a classmate is hurting too. The team chooses kindness and action: Harman supports, Daman shows how to block and report, and Byte reminds everyone that **no one is alone**.

Your four moves

- **Block:** stop the person from contacting you
- **Report:** use the app's report option
- **Save evidence:** screenshots with date and username
- **Support:** check in with the person affected

Do

- Tell a trusted adult, teacher or parent
- Limit who can comment and message you
- Reach out kindly to the person targeted
- Take a break from the app if it affects you

Don't

- Do not reply or retaliate
- Do not like, share or laugh at hurtful posts
- Do not delete evidence before saving it
- Do not blame the person being bullied

GETTING HELP

Threats, blackmail or sharing private photos are crimes. Report at **cybercrime.gov.in** or call **1930**. Children can call **Childline 1098**. If someone feels very low, **Tele-MANAS 14416** offers free mental health support.

BYTE'S GOLDEN RULE **You're not alone. Block, report, save evidence, support.**

8 Public Wi-Fi Mission

UNSAFE NETWORKS



THE STORY

At a café, Raman spots a free Wi-Fi network with a warning sign. Daman explains that open networks can be **faked or watched** by attackers, while Harman uses her trusted mobile data for anything sensitive.

Red flags	Do	Don't
• Open networks with no password • A name that looks like the café's but is slightly different • Login pages asking for card details or OTP • Phone joins Wi-Fi automatically without asking	• Ask staff for the exact network name and password • Use mobile data for banking, UPI and shopping • Switch off auto-join / auto-connect • Look for the HTTPS padlock and keep apps updated	• Do not bank or use UPI on public Wi-Fi • Do not log into important accounts on shared networks • Do not ignore "not secure" warnings • Do not leave Wi-Fi switched on when not needed

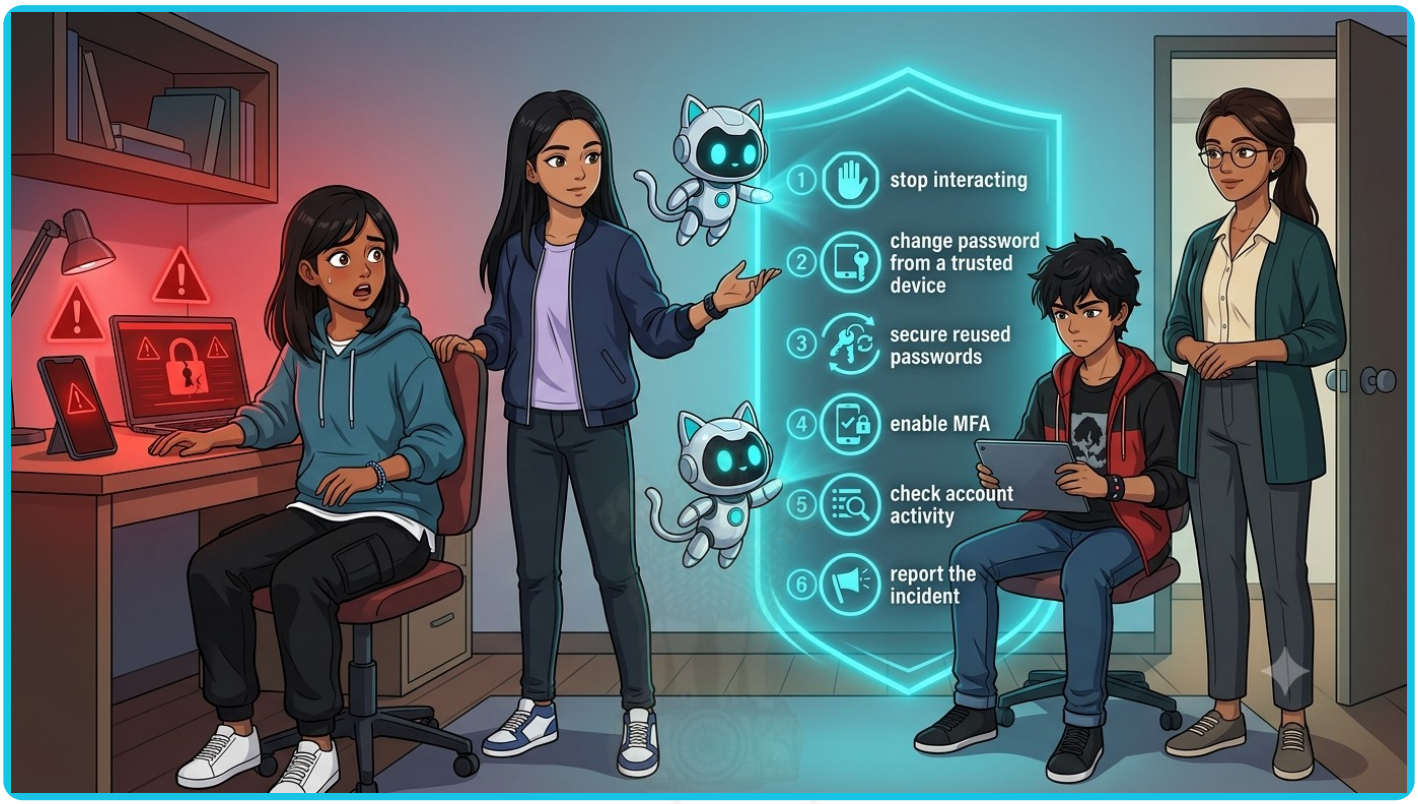
IF IT ALREADY HAPPENED

Used public Wi-Fi for something sensitive? Change that account's password from a trusted network, turn on MFA, and check recent activity and transactions.

BYTE'S GOLDEN RULE **Sensitive tasks belong on a trusted connection. Turn auto-join off.**

9 You've Been Hacked!

EMERGENCY RESPONSE



THE STORY

Harman accidentally typed her password into a fake website. Instead of panicking, the team follows a clear plan with **Jassi** calmly guiding. Fast action limits the damage.

Right now

- **1. Stop interacting.** Close the page, do not click anything else
- **2. Change your password from a trusted device.** Use your own phone or computer, not the affected one

Next

- **3. Fix reused passwords.** Change every account that used the same password
- **4. Turn on MFA.** Add a second lock to email, banking and social accounts

Then

- **5. Check account activity.** Look at login history, sent messages, transactions and linked devices
- **6. Report it.** Tell your bank or platform, and report at cybercrime.gov.in or **1930**

IF MONEY WAS TAKEN

Call your **bank immediately** to block cards and UPI, then call **1930** as fast as possible. Speed matters. Keep screenshots, messages and transaction IDs. Do not feel ashamed: scammers fool smart people every day.

BYTE'S GOLDEN RULE **Stay calm, act fast, follow the six steps, and tell someone you trust.**

10 Cyber Guardian

THE FIVE CHECKS



THE STORY

Harman, Daman, Raman, Jassi and Byte stand together under a shield of safe habits. Five quick questions, shown as icons around the shield, work for **every scam in this book**.

Who? and Why?

- **Who** is this really? Verify through an official app, website or number
- **Why** are they asking? Real organisations rarely demand OTPs, PINs or urgent payments

Where? and Private?

- **Where** does the link or QR code lead? Check before you click or scan
- Is this **private**? Keep personal and financial details to yourself

Pause

- **Pause** before acting. Scams depend on speed
- Ask someone you trust if you are unsure
- Report scams so others are protected

SPREAD THE SHIELD

Teach one person this week, especially older relatives and children. Show them the five checks and the helplines on the last page. A protected community is a safer internet for everyone.

BYTE'S GOLDEN RULE **Who? Why? Where? Private? Pause. Five checks, every time.**

? Test Yourself: Scam or Safe?

QUICK QUIZ

1	An SMS from an unknown number: “Your bank account will be blocked in 1 hour. Click to complete KYC.”	☐ Scam	☐ Safe
2	A saved contact, your friend, texts: “Hey, lunch at 1 today?” with no link.	☐ Scam	☐ Safe
3	A buyer asks you to scan a QR code and enter your UPI PIN to “receive” payment.	☐ Scam	☐ Safe
4	You want to pay your electricity bill using a café’s open Wi-Fi.	☐ Scam	☐ Safe
5	A website sells a ₹1,00,000 phone for ₹4,999 with a 5-minute countdown.	☐ Scam	☐ Safe
6	You are on holiday and want to post a photo with your location tagged, right now.	☐ Scam	☐ Safe

ANSWERS

1. **Scam.** Urgency + link. Open your bank’s official app instead.
2. **Likely safe,** but call if it ever feels unusual.
3. **Scam.** You never need a PIN to receive money.
4. **Not safe.** Use mobile data for payments.
5. **Scam.** Impossible price plus fake urgency.
6. **Wait.** Post after you are back home.

If Something Goes Wrong

NATIONAL CYBER CRIME HELPLINE

1930

Report online fraud at

cybercrime.gov.in

Report fast. Early reports give the best chance of stopping the loss.

Your bank

Number on the back of your card. Block cards and UPI first.

Childline 1098

Free helpline for children in distress, including online abuse.

Tele-MANAS 14416

Free mental health support if bullying or fraud is affecting you.

Emergency 112

If someone is in immediate danger or being threatened.

MY CYBER SAFETY PLEDGE

- I will pause before clicking links, scanning QR codes or sharing OTPs.
- I will use a long, unique password and turn on MFA.
- I will keep my accounts private and post holiday photos after I return.
- I will use mobile data, not public Wi-Fi, for banking and UPI.
- I will block, report and support if I see online bullying.
- I will teach one person what I learned here.

Helpline numbers were correct at the time of writing. Please confirm them on official government and bank websites before printing or distributing.